

SNEAKY PEEK

Near-death experiences are sometimes reported by people who have come very close to death, either as a result of serious illness or injury. They talk afterward of seeing a bright light, sunny green meadows, or crowds of smiling people. They describe feeling an incredible and overwhelming sense of peace. Were they peeking through heaven's gates or was it all just a dream?

CELESTIAL ADDRESS

The location of heaven varies by religion, too, but it is a common belief that heaven is up in the sky, beyond the clouds, stars, and other planets in the universe. In contrast, hell is thought to be down in the fiery depths of Earth's core. Heaven is described as the place from where the stars shine. Some Christians believe that heaven will one day be made here on Earth.

STRAIGHT UP

WISHFUL THINKING

The texts of Islam describe heaven as a luxurious place where the residents dress in fancy clothes, eat delicious food, and live in beautiful palaces with their families. No one wants for anything because each and every wish is granted. In the highest level, seventh heaven, you can sometimes see God.

HEAVEN-SENT

Other religions teach that heaven is not actually a place. In some Chinese faiths, heaven is like an all-seeing, all-knowing God rather than a location. The Roman Catholic church says that heaven is a state of being, in a joyful union with God. Happiness is an absolute guarantee.

THE BEAUTIFUL ONES

Who lives in heaven? In some faiths, God lives there with his believers. Your dearly departed ancestors may be waiting there to see you again. Some faiths say that all children go straight to heaven after death, regardless of whether they have been naughty or were not religious. One thing is certain: it's a great neighborhood. There is no sickness, ugliness, hunger, or unhappiness. Even if your appearance wasn't heavenly on Earth, you will look simply divine in heaven.

**"EARTH HAS NO
SORROW THAT HEAVEN
CANNOT HEAL."**

Thomas Moore (1779-1852),
Irish poet